



WATCH THE
VIDEO



Jonathan Selvaraj

jonathan.selvaraj@thehindu.co.in

Whenever Indian wrestler Sujeet Kalkal feels short of motivation, he pulls out his phone and looks at the wallpaper. The 22-year-old has had his share of wrestling highlights recently. In July, Sujeet won India's first gold medal of the year at the UWW (United World Wrestling) Ranking Series in Budapest, defeating Olympic bronze medallist Islam Dudaev of Albania, two-time Olympian Vazgen Tevanyan of Armenia, and four-time European medallist Ali Rahimzade of Azerbaijan in the men's 65kg division.

In a strong field, Sujeet scored 33

points while conceding just two across four matches — a result that marks him as a potential medal contender at the World Championships in September.

The picture on Sujeet's phone, however, isn't from Budapest. It's from Istanbul, taken during last year's World Wrestling Olympic Qualification Tournament, where he experienced one of the lowest moments of his career. Having won the selection trials in India, Sujeet had hoped to qualify for the Paris Games at the Asian Olympic Qualifiers in Jordan. But in a turn of misfortune, his connecting flight to Amman was delayed due to a record-breaking flood in Dubai.

At the World Qualifiers — a much tougher field — Sujeet made it to the

semifinals, needing just one more win to book his Olympic ticket. But he fell short. He lost 6-1 to Mongolia's Tulga Tomor-Ochiryn, and then came agonisingly close against World Champion Zain Retherford of the USA, losing 2-2 on criteria. *(Sujeet lost because Retherford scored the final takedown)*

It's a picture of the match against Tulga that Sujeet glances at every time he picks up his phone. While most athletes might have been bitterly disappointed about missing out on making their Olympic debut, Sujeet sees things differently. "Although I lost, I consider these two defeats to be the most important matches for me. I might have qualified for the Olympics had I